THE

# ARCANE AETHER

*A rules-light fantasy game about rewriting reality*

VERSION 4.6 · INITIAL FULL-BOOK DRAFT

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# The Arcane Aether

The Arcane Aether is a rules-light fantasy game about ordinary people who discover that reality can be rewritten.
I am trying to explore two ideas with these rules:

- Can magic stay open-ended and weird while still being fun at the table?
- Can a simple system let characters progress during play, as a direct result of the choices made in a session?

It is inspired by Powered by the Apocalypse, Shadowdark, Blades in the Dark, Cairn, and other games where characters take shape through play.
I am not very concerned with encounter balance, and the game does not offer many guardrails. I want something quick to learn and quick to get into play, with room for silly, out-of-the-box ideas. I also like the thought that you can borrow magic from any other game and see what it does here.
As a GM, I like to play to find out and leave room for freeform play. I want simple monster creation and fast, fluid fights when the players decide to fight.

## Origin of magic relics

Why are there so many magic items? Why do the people capable of making them keep leaving them in tombs, shops, and holes in the ground?
In this game, Arcanists make magic items because they need somewhere to put their Exposure before it changes them. They pour it into objects, use those objects for a while, and eventually have to leave some of them behind.
Every relic came from someone with a problem. That was the idea I wanted to explore, and the rest of the game grew around it.

## What makes it different

There is no spell list. A player says what they want their character's magic to do. The GM assigns one Magic Magnitude for the whole effect, then the player decides if it is worth the Exposure.
You do not need to predict every possible spell. You just need to understand what the player is asking for and make the Exposure cost clear.

### Advance by trying in play

I want character progression to happen while everyone is playing, not as a separate downtime step or paperwork after the game. Characters gain Luck when things go badly and when they complete their goals.
Players can spend that Luck to improve their character's stats, help one another, or play out a flashback scene that changes the present scene. Players learn to be better at casting by attempting to cast, but at the cost of slowly collecting mutations that fill up their limited inventory. It should be clear that all obstacles in this game are solvable through magic and teamwork.

### Monsters should be easy to run

A monster needs four numbers and answers to two questions: what does it want, and what is its weakness?
Monster tiers are numbered 1 to 6. When I do not want to decide how dangerous something should be, I let the dice decide.
I do not think every encounter needs to be balanced. Tell the players what their characters can see, let them decide what risks to take, and follow the consequences. The monster's Desire also leaves room for a bargain when another attack roll would be less interesting.

### Strange ideas are allowed to work

Not everything needs a roll. Let the silly ideas move the story. Maybe a character knows how to speak Orc because they once spent a summer in an Orc camp pretending to be a baby Orc's doll, that sounds good to me.

# Core Rules

The Arcane Aether is a rules-light game about ordinary people who can reshape reality and must live with the cost.

## The dice

Say what your character intends to do. **Roll 2d6 plus the fitting stat.** Casting uses one relevant Spell Tag instead. Roll when the outcome is uncertain and failure would change the situation. Otherwise, let it happen or tell the player what it costs in time or resources.

| Total | Result |
|---|---|
| 6 or less | Failure. It goes wrong. Resolve the failure, then gain 1 Luck. |
| 7 to 9 | Partial success. Your character does it, but there is a complication. |
| 10 or greater | Full success. Your character achieves what they intended. |
| Double 1s | Tragic failure. |
| Double 6s | Critical success. |

Check doubles on the two dice that determine the result. Double 1s or double 6s replace the normal result.
When no more specific doubles rule applies, the GM adds a severe or lasting consequence to a Tragic failure. On a Critical success, your character achieves what they intended and gains an extra benefit chosen by the GM.
A complication should move events forward. Your character might lose something, end up in danger, attract attention, or get hurt. A partial success still accomplishes what you rolled for.

## Luck

Each character can hold up to **10 Luck**.
At the table, use spare d6s or tokens to track Luck. Each die or token represents 1 Luck, regardless of the number showing on the die. Collect them as you gain Luck and return them as you spend it. At the end of the session, record the remaining total in the Luck box on your character sheet. Use that total to set out your dice or tokens next session.
Gain **1 Luck** after you accept and resolve a failed roll. Gain **2 Luck** when your character achieves a Key Goal and you cross it off their list.
You may give your Luck to another player whenever you like.

### Spending Luck

| Cost | Buy |
|---|---|
| 1 | Add one die to your roll and keep the highest two. |
| 1 | Assist another character. With their roll by rolling 1 dice with them. |
| 2 | Play a flashback that can affect the present. |
| 5 | Advance your character. |

### Add a die

Spend 1 Luck before resolving a roll. Roll **3d6 and keep the highest two**. Only the kept dice count for double 1s or double 6s.

### Assist another character

Spend 1 Luck and explain how your character helps. The active player adds 1d6 to their roll and keeps the highest two dice.
If the roll fails, only the active player gains 1 Luck. Everyone who assisted shares the consequences of a failure or partial success.
You can spend a luck to assist while the other player is spending a luck to add a dice.

### Flashbacks

Spend 2 Luck to play a short scene from your character's past that affects the present. Maybe they bribed the kitchen servant to leave the back door unlocked.
Play the scene and roll if its outcome is uncertain. Then return to the present with the result. Costs and consequences apply normally. In a turn, the flashback counts as your character's action.

### Advancement

Spend 5 Luck to choose one:

- Increase a stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.
- Increase a Spell Tag by 1, to a maximum of +3.
- Increase maximum Health by 1.
- Gain an Archetype Perk.

## Magical casting

Your character can command the patterns of Aether and reshape reality through thought and imagination.

1. Describe the effect: its reach or size, what it does, and how long it lasts.
2. The GM assigns one Magic Magnitude for the whole effect and states its Exposure cost.
3. Agree on what the spell will do, including any damage, healing, and when it ends.
4. Accept the final cost or reduce the effect, then roll 2d6 plus one relevant Spell Tag.

Casting follows the normal roll results, with these additional effects:

- **Failure:** The cast fails and costs no Exposure. Resolve the failure, then gain 1 Luck.
- **Partial success:** The cast works. Mark the agreed Exposure and suffer a complication.
- **Full success:** The cast works. Mark the agreed Exposure. If the spell deals damage, deal double its standard damage. Add a beneficial flourish beyond the intended effect.
- **Double 1s:** The cast fails spectacularly. Caster takes no Exposure. Roll d66 on the Wild Magic table.
- **Double 6s:** The cast works. Mark the agreed Exposure, then gain a new Spell Tag related to the cast or increase the Tag used by 1, to a maximum of +3.

A beneficial flourish to the cast can be added to the scene when it makes sense in the story.

## Spell Tags

Spell Tags represent what your character has learned through casting. Fire, invisibility, healing, ice, mind reading, floating, talking to animals, light, pain, and poison are all possible Tags.

Choose one relevant Spell Tag for each cast and add its rating to the roll. Tags do not stack, run out, reduce Exposure, or limit what your character may attempt. Without a relevant Tag, roll 2d6 with no bonus.

Casting never uses a Stat. Only one relevant Spell Tag can add to the roll.

When your character gains a Mutation through casting or you roll double 6s on a cast, gain a new +1 Tag related to the cast or increase the Tag used by 1, to a maximum of +3. If both happen on the same cast, gain this benefit only once.

The Spell Tags table is a prompt sheet, not a spell list.

## Exposure Tolerance

Mutations allow your character's body to withstand more Exposure. Their Tolerance for one cast is:

**Tolerance = 3 + their number of Mutations.**

Your character may attempt magic above their Tolerance. On a success, mark the full Exposure and resolve any resulting Mutations. Then mark 1 Fatigue for each point of the spell's Exposure above their Tolerance. A failed cast causes no Exposure or Fatigue.

For example, a character with one Mutation has Tolerance 4. A Medium spell costs 4 Exposure and causes no Fatigue. A Large spell costs 6 Exposure and causes 2 Fatigue.

## Magic Magnitude

The GM assigns one magnitude based on the spell's overall scale, power, reach, and duration. Use the examples as guides. Do not add separate costs for each part of the effect.

| Magnitude | Exposure | Damage guideline | Example |
|---|---|---|---|
| Tiny | 1 | 0 | Create a harmless spark on something the character touches. |
| Small | 2 | 1 | Give one nearby creature a firm magical shove. |
| Medium | 4 | 2 | Fill a room with an illusion for a scene. |
| Large | 6 | 3 | Hide a building or group of buildings behind an illusion. |
| Huge | 8 | 4 | Cover a field or city in magical fog. |
| Mythic | 10 | 8 | Permanently transform a whole building into a living creature. |

A Small ongoing effect lasts a few rounds. Keeping the effect going for hours requires a higher magnitude. A spell lasting a few days suggests Large; one lasting a few months suggests Huge. These are benchmarks for the whole effect, not separate allowances. Lighting a city's lamps is less demanding than destroying every building in it.

Non-damaging magic uses the same scale. Damage is a guideline, not a requirement: a spell can have a large reach or long duration without dealing damage. Agree on its standard damage before rolling. On a full success of 10 or greater, double that damage. For example, Huge magic normally deals 4 damage, or 8 on a full success. Mythic magic normally deals 8 damage, or 16 on a full success. Tiny magic deals no direct damage.

For scrying, mind reading, and other information magic, consider how far away the subject is, what the character learns, and how long they observe. Discovery, misleading visions, or the subject sensing the intrusion may still be consequences when they fit.

Casting effects end when their agreed duration expires. A portal closes, a transformed person returns to their previous form, invisibility ends, and a flying boat comes back down.

## Magical healing

Medium magic handles simple injuries, normally restoring 2 Health. Large magic handles major wounds, normally restoring 3 Health, or removing one Scar. The GM considers the whole effect when assigning magnitude, including how many characters it heals and how long it lasts. Fatigue still prevents Health recovery.

Damage and healing normally happen instantly and remain afterward. Each character can benefit from a healing zone once per cast.

Magic may start a fire, but the fire continues only while it has fuel.

## Exposure and Mutation

Exposure is a little like radiation poisoning. It collects as your character uses the Arcane Aether, letting them reshape the world while it reshapes them.

Whenever the character reaches **10 Exposure**, they undergo a Mutation. Roll on the Mutation table.

The Mutation permanently occupies an inventory slot.

Subtract 10 Exposure and keep any excess.

If a cast also causes Fatigue, resolve its Exposure and any resulting Mutations before marking the Fatigue.

## Magic items

An Arcanist, or caster, can move Exposure out of their body and into an object, creating a magical relic.

A relic:

- Takes one inventory slot.
- Holds up to **10 Exposure**.
- Takes an undisturbed hour to create or refill.
- Has one magical function chosen when it is created.
- Can be created or refilled once per in-game day.

Creating a new relic consumes **2 of the character's current Exposure**. This Exposure is spent, not stored.

During the same hour, choose how much additional Exposure to transfer, up to the relic's capacity. Subtract it from the character's current Exposure and record it in the relic.

For example, creating a relic with 4 stored Exposure removes 6 Exposure from the character: 2 to make the object magical and 4 to store. A new relic may start empty. Refilling an existing relic costs only the Exposure transferred, with no creation cost.

Anyone who can operate the relic can activate it. Describe an effect within the relic's function. The GM assigns its Magic Magnitude using the normal casting guidelines. Subtract that magnitude's Exposure cost from the relic's stored Exposure. No casting roll is made, and the character using it gains no Exposure or Fatigue.

The relic cannot produce an activation that costs more Exposure than it currently holds. At zero Exposure, it is inert until an Arcanist refills it. It remains a relic and does not need the creation cost paid again.

Get creative with your magic items. Like a soul jar thats holds more gear, a fork that shoots fire balls, gloves that put people to sleep.

Relics can be traded or sold like other valuable objects.

## Inventory and conditions

Your inventory is a mix of the things you have on you and your health bar.

Your character has **12 inventory slots**. Gear fills from the top down. Conditions fill from the bottom up, taking the lowest available slot.

An item usually takes one slot. Small things of the same kind bundle together, such as a handful of arrows, spikes, or three rations. Worn armor does not take a slot.

Mutations, Scars, and Fatigue are conditions. If one takes a slot holding an item, that item is dropped.

When conditions claim all twelve slots, the character is lost. The final condition determines what happens in Death and dying.

## Movement

A move shifts your character one zone toward or away from something. Skip their action to take a second move.

| Zone | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Close | Melee. Close enough to touch. |
| Near | Across the room. One move to Close. |
| Far | Two moves from Close. Bowshot. |

Walls, locked doors, crowds, and deep holes still matter.

## Combat

Characters act first, then enemies. The players roll 1d6. The highest roll goes first, then play moves clockwise around the table. If the characters are surprised, the attackers act first.

### Your character's turn

Your character can take **one move and one action** in either order. They can attack, cast, catch their breath, use something, assist someone, or try something else.

Roll **2d6 plus Strength** for hand-to-hand combat or **2d6 plus Dexterity** for a ranged attack. Your character must be able to reach the target with what they are using.

| Result | Effect |
|---|---|
| Failure | The attack fails and the situation gets worse. |
| Partial success | Deal the weapon's damage and suffer a complication. |
| Full success | Deal double the weapon's damage. |
| Double 6s | Deal triple damage and ignore Armor. |
| Double 1s | The attack fails. The character takes 1 damage or their weapon breaks, whichever fits. |
| Triple 6s | You daftly kill your target. |
| Triple 1s | Take a scare and drop your weapon. You blundered so bad you fell and hurt yourself. |

On a failure or partial success, an enemy may hurt your character, push them back, damage their gear, or create another fitting complication. The enemy still takes its regular turn.

### Damage and Armor

Damage uses the same magnitude names as magic:

| Damage magnitude | Damage |
|---|---|
| Tiny | 0 |
| Small | 1 |
| Medium | 2 |
| Large | 3 |
| Huge | 4 |
| Mythic | 8 |

These names describe damage, not the size of the weapon or the monster's tier. Damage modifiers, doubling, tripling, and Armor still apply normally. A Mythic monster still follows its own Weakness rules in Monsters.

Weapons deal damage based on their size and weight:

- Small or concealable: **Small damage (1)**.
- Normal: **Medium damage (2)**.
- Heavy or two-handed: **Large damage (3)**.

Apply damage added by a Perk before doubling or tripling the attack.

Armor reduces incoming damage. Worn armor and shields stack to a maximum of **3 Armor**, although Mythic creatures may have more.

When your character takes damage, subtract their Armor. If the damage exceeds the Armor, apply the remaining damage and the Armor breaks. If the damage does not exceed the Armor, apply no damage and leave the Armor intact.

A critical success ignores Armor without breaking it. Broken Armor must be repaired by someone with the necessary skills. Pay them or owe them a favor.

### When enemies attack

Use the enemy's Threat from Monsters. The GM rolls **2d6 plus Threat**.

| Total | Result |
|---|---|
| 6 or less | The attack misses. |
| 7 to 9 | Deal the enemy's listed damage. |
| 10 or greater | Deal the enemy's listed damage and cause a complication. |
| Double 6s | Deal triple damage and ignore Armor. |
| Double 1s | The attack fails and the enemy suffers a mishap. |

A crowd attacking one target rolls once, using its highest Threat and best single damage. Its numbers can still block exits, surround a character, or create other complications.

## Health, Scars, and recovery

Subtract damage from your character's current Health. Their Archetype sets the maximum. Health cannot fall below zero.

Reaching zero Health does not cause a Scar. When your character takes damage while already at zero Health, mark one Scar. A single hit causes only one Scar, regardless of how much damage it deals.

Each Scar occupies an inventory slot until removed. Restoring Health does not remove Scars.

### Healing

- **One quiet hour in a safe place:** Roll 2d6 and restore that much Health if your character has no Fatigue.
- **A full night's rest:** Remove one Fatigue. If none remains afterward, restore all Health.

To catch their breath, spend the character's action and roll **2d6 plus Willpower**. They cannot do this while Fatigued.

| Total | Result |
|---|---|
| 6 or less | Restore no Health. The situation gets worse. After resolving the failure, gain 1 Luck. |
| 7 to 9 | Restore 1 Health. |
| 10 or greater | Restore 2 Health. |
| Double 1s | Restore no Health and resolve a Tragic failure. |
| Double 6s | Restore 3 Health. On the character's next turn, roll 3d6 and keep the highest two for their first roll. |

Health cannot exceed the character's maximum. Fatigue prevents all Health recovery, including magical healing.

Removing a Scar requires magic or about a week of care from a healer. Removing it frees its inventory slot.

## Death and dying

The condition that claims your character's final inventory slot determines their fate.

| Final condition | Ending |
|---|---|
| Mutation | The character becomes a Demon. The Aether has changed them beyond themselves. |
| Scar | The character's body dies. Their spirit passes on, or lingers because of unfinished business. |
| Fatigue | The character is taken by the Aether. They have nothing left to hold it back. |

The character becomes part of the world's lore, and the player makes someone new. A lingering spirit may still matter, but the character's playable life is over.

# Character Creation

Make someone who had a life before they became an Arcanist. Four steps are enough to begin. The rest can come out during play.

## Step 1: Basic details

Give your character a name and a few details: their age, appearance, voice, and where they are from. A line is plenty.

Then choose a Life Type and record both of its traits. Humans, elves, goblins, cat people, karate turtles, and stranger things all have a place in this world.

### Life types

#### Human

- **Resilient:** Once a day, ignore one Fatigue as it would be marked.
- **I Know a Guy:** Once per session, declare that your character knows someone useful in the current location. Tell the table how they know each other.

#### Elf

- **Foresight:** Play one free flashback per session.
- **Old Grudge:** When old knowledge or an old event matters, your character remembers because they were there.

#### Goblin

- **Overlooked:** Add +1 when your character hides, squeezes, scurries, or goes unnoticed.
- **Goblin Friends:** If a goblin is involved, your character knows them. Tell the table how.

#### Beastfolk

Choose the animal that shapes your character.

- **Natural Weapons:** Their unarmed attacks deal 2 damage.
- **Keen Senses:** Add +1 when they use one heightened sense appropriate to that animal.

#### Otherfolk

Otherfolk includes people commonly thought of as monsters, such as crab people, intelligent oozes, lizard folk, vampires, or skeletons.

Choose one body advantage that fits what your character is. Describe what it lets them do.

Examples:

- A shell or thick hide gives 1 Armor.
- A lizard person may use their tail as a weapon.
- A vampire may turn into a bat.
- A skeleton may detach and reattach their limbs.

## Step 2: Choose an Archetype

Your character's Archetype represents the life they led before becoming an Arcanist.

Choose one. Take its starting gear, maximum Health, and one Perk. Use its suggested Stats, or arrange **+2, +1, 0, and –1** across the four Stats yourself.

| Stat | What it covers |
|---|---|
| Strength | Muscle, force, fighting hand to hand |
| Dexterity | Speed, stealth, precision, ranged attacks |
| Willpower | Endurance and resolve |
| Charm | Persuasion and presence |

Set your character's current Health equal to their maximum Health.

| Archetype | Old life | Health |
|---|---|---|
| Hunter | Tracked Arcanists for coin, then woke up as one. | 7 |
| Thief | Lived by wit, speed, and other people's things. | 6 |
| Performer | Lived by fast talk and knowing everyone worth knowing. | 6 |
| Monk | Studied the ancient arts and honed their body into a weapon. | 7 |
| Fighter | Someone paid them to stand in the way, and they never learned to stop. | 8 |
| Witch | Had a place in an order once, then something answered. | 5 |

If none fit, work with the GM to create an old life. Use the same Stat array and choose starting gear, maximum Health, and one Perk based on the existing Archetypes.

### Pack the gear

Your character has **12 inventory slots**. Put their Archetype gear into the slots from the top down. Worn Armor does not take a slot.

Small things of the same kind bundle together. Three rations, a handful of arrows, or several iron spikes each take one slot.

Roll **2d6 and multiply the total by 10** for your character's starting coin. Record it in the Coin box on their sheet.

## Step 3: Key goals

Write up to four Key Goals your character wants to achieve. They should matter enough to make the character go out into the world and do something about them.

They can be serious or ridiculous:

- Get revenge on the person who killed their mother.
- Burn down the silly hat shop.
- Find out what happened to their sister.
- Buy back the family house.

Choose goals with a clear end. When your character achieves one, cross it off and gain **2 Luck**.
Share the goals with the other players. Their characters might share one, want to help, or have a very good reason to keep that hat shop standing.

## Step 4: Starting mutation

Decide whether the Aether has already changed your character.

### Start Unchanged

- Begin with no Mutations and no Spell Tags.
- Their Exposure Tolerance is 3.
- Begin with 0 current Exposure, 0 Luck, no Scars, and no Fatigue.

### Start Marked

- Roll on the Mutation table and record the result in inventory slot 12.
- Choose one +1 Spell Tag related to the Mutation or the event that made the character an Arcanist.
- Their Exposure Tolerance is 4.
- Begin with 0 current Exposure, 0 Luck, no Scars, and no Fatigue.

Starting Marked gives the character more control over magic, but the Aether has already taken one of their twelve slots.

# Archetypes

## Hunter

Tracked Arcanists for coin, then woke up as one.

| Strength | Dexterity | Willpower | Charm |
|---|---|---|---|
| +2 | 0 | +1 | −1 |

**Starting Health** 7

***Starting Gear***

*Short sword, 2 damage*

*Crossbow, 2 damage*

*Manacles*

*Iron spikes*

*Big hammer, 1 damage*

*Rations x3*

*Chainmail, Armor 1*

| d6 | Perk |
|---|---|
| 1 | Roll with advantage when following tracks. |
| 2 | Add Dexterity to damage with a bow or crossbow. |
| 3 | Roll with advantage when telling if someone is lying. |
| 4 | Pinning Shot: When you roll double 4s on a ranged attack, your character may pin the target's clothing or body to a nearby surface. The target must spend an action pulling free. Resolve damage and complications normally. |
| 5 | Your character is an expert at barbecuing meat |
| 6 | Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3. |

## Thief

Lived by wit, speed, and other people's things.

| Strength | Dexterity | Willpower | Charm |
|---|---|---|---|
| −1 | +2 | +1 | 0 |

**Starting Health** 6

***Starting Gear***

*Double daggers, 2 damage*

*Leather Armor, Armor 1*

*Lockpick kit*

*Grappling hook*

*60 feet of rope*

*Smoke pellets that hide the character from sight*

*Rations x3*

| d6 | Perk |
|---|---|
| 1 | Super Taster: Your character can identify a substance by tasting even the smallest trace. Poison, strange ink, expensive perfume, someone's lunch. They can even tell what kind of creature left a smear of dried blood. Knowing what it is does not make it safe to taste. |
| 2 | Deal +1 damage to something that has not seen your character. |
| 3 | Roll with advantage when pickpocketing or lock-picking. |
| 4 | Vital Strike: When you roll double 4s while stabbing a creature unaware of your character's presence, the blade finds a vital spot. The creature dies before the blade is pulled free. Mythic creatures still require their Weakness to be exploited. |
| 5 | Call in a Favor: Once a session, you can declare that a thief, smuggler, or other shady person nearby owes your character a small favor. Neither is willing to explain why. |
| 6 | Rat Whisperer: Your character can talk with rats and bargain with them to run errands, spy, collect information, or do other favors. Rats want food or favors in return, and their requests are not always reasonable. |

# Performer

Lived by fast talk and knowing everyone worth knowing.

| Strength | Dexterity | Willpower | Charm |
|---|---|---|---|
| –1 | +1 | 0 | +2 |

**Starting Health** **6**

***Starting Gear***

*Short sword, 2 damage*

*Disguise kit*

*A ring of stolen keys*

*Padded coat, Armor 1*

*Torch*

*Rations x3*

| d6 | Perk |
|---|---|
| 1 | Once a session, name someone who owes your character a favor. They do. |
| 2 | Musical Number: Once a day, your character can entice a roomful of ordinary people into an elaborate song and choreographed dance. Bakers, pickpockets, and visiting aunts know every word and step, and gleefully join in to perform the number. |
| 3 | Strangers assume your character belongs here until given a reason to doubt it. |
| 4 | Kindred Spirits: When you roll double 4s on a Charm roll, your character and the target form a sudden, deep, and lasting bond. Neither can explain it, but both feel it. Resolve the roll normally. |
| 5 | Once a day, your character knows the perfect song for this moment. |
| 6 | Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3. |

# Monk

Studied the ancient arts and honed their body into a weapon.

| Strength | Dexterity | Willpower | Charm |
|---|---|---|---|
| +1 | +2 | 0 | –1 |

**Starting Health** 7

***Starting Gear***

*Walking staff, 2 damage*

*Bandages and salves, 3 uses, restore 1d6 Health*

*60 feet of knotted rope*

*Throwing stars x4*

*Torch*

*Rations x3*

| d6 | Perk |
|---|---|
| 1 | Add Strength to damage with unarmed strikes. |
| 2 | Gain +1 Armor while your character can move freely. |
| 3 | Your character can leap 20 feet and perch on anything that will hold a toe. |
| 4 | Sweeping Strike: When you roll double 4s on an unarmed attack, your character may knock the target off their feet. The target must spend their move standing up. Resolve damage and complications normally. |
| 5 | Your character can enchant creatures and people with music. |
| 6 | Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3. |

# Fighter

Someone paid your character to stand in the way, and they never learned to stop.

| Strength | Dexterity | Willpower | Charm |
|---|---|---|---|
| +2 | +1 | 0 | –1 |

**Starting Health** 8

***Starting Gear***

*Longsword, 3 damage*

*Chainmail, Armor 1*

*Shield, Armor 1*

*Torch x2*

*Rations x3*

| d6 | Perk |
|---|---|
| 1 | Add Strength to damage in hand-to-hand combat. |
| 2 | Once a fight, take a hit meant for someone at Close range. |
| 3 | Choose your favorite Armor and gain an extra +1 Armor while your character wears it. |
| 4 | Disarm: When you roll double 4s on a melee attack, your character may knock a weapon from the target's hand. Resolve damage and complications normally. |
| 5 | Your character can mend a battlefield wound and restore 1 Health as an action. |
| 6 | Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3. |

# Witch

Had a place in an order once, then something answered.

| Strength | Dexterity | Willpower | Charm |
|---|---|---|---|
| –1 | 0 | +2 | +1 |

**Starting Health** 5

***Starting Gear***

*A staff from the character's old order, holding 9 Exposure and an effect they did not create*

*Sleep powder*

*A bone-handled knife, 2 damage*

*Torch*

*Rations x3*

| d6 | Perk |
|---|---|
| 1 | Striking beauty: Once a long rest, you can charm people simply by getting them to look at you for one round. |
| 2 | 1. Spell Tag: Gain or improve a Spell Tag when the kept casting dice are double 4s. |
| 3 | Explosive knowledge: You know how make bombs out of common plants and chemicals |
| 4 | Cat Friends: Your character can befriend as many ordinary cats as they wish. Roll to see if they follow your character's orders. |
| 5 | Talented caster: Roll with advantage when casting with a Spell Tag. |
| 6 | Crow Friends: Your character has a murder of crows that obeys your commands. |

# Game Master Guide

## Monsters

Four numbers and two questions.

**Threat, Damage, Health, Armor, then what undoes it and what it wants.** That fits on an index card.

### Tiers

| d6 | Tier | Stats and example |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Pest** | **Threat:** –1; **Damage:** 1; **Health:** 3; **Armor:** 0; Goblin. |
| 2 | **Minion** | **Threat:** 0; **Damage:** 2; **Health:** 5; **Armor:** 1; Bandit or bear. |
| 3 | **Glass Cannon** | **Threat:** +1; **Damage:** 3; **Health:** 10; **Armor:** 0; Mummy. |
| 4 | **Horror** | **Threat:** +2; **Damage:** 3; **Health:** 15; **Armor:** 2; Ooze. |
| 5 | **Boss** | **Threat:** +2; **Damage:** 4; **Health:** 20; **Armor:** 3; Demon. |
| 6 | **Mythic** | **Threat:** +3; **Damage:** 5; **Health:** 30; **Armor:** 5; Dragon. |

Choose the tier level that fits, or roll 1d6 and let the dice decide. Rolling works well when you are improvising or want the danger to surprise you too.

### Running one

- Roll 2d6 plus Threat when a monster attacks. See Core Rules.
- Damage applies to all its attacks. A bear might bite or swipe, but both deal 2 damage.
- Weakness is what gives the characters an edge. Plant a way to discover it: a corpse, a book, a survivor, or someone who faced the creature before.
- Desire is what the monster wants besides killing the characters. Anything with a Desire can potentially be bargained with.
- For a monster caster, roll twice on Spell Tag Sparks and combine the results into a casting theme.
- A group of monsters attacking one character at the same time rolls once, using its highest Threat and best single Damage. Its numbers can still surround characters, block exits, or create other complications.
- A monster with Threat +2 or higher can attack twice on its turn. An individual monster may break this rule when it fits.

Worked monsters are in the Bestiary.

### Morale

When a monster falls to half Health or less, roll 2d6 plus Threat.

| Total | Result |
|---|---|
| 6 or less | It flees, surrenders, or bargains. |
| 7 to 9 | It changes tactics or pursues its Desire. |
| 10 or greater | It holds. |

The GM may call for another morale roll after the monster takes more damage. Mindless, driven, or bound creatures do not roll Morale.

### Mythic monsters

Health alone never kills a Mythic. Its Weakness is the only thing that can end it.

When a Mythic reaches zero Health without its Weakness being exploited, it withdraws or changes. If it changes, restore its Health and make it worse.

Telegraph this from the beginning. Wounds close. Severed limbs reform. The blade comes away clean. Killing the figure beneath the robe only kills the robe.

# Bestiary

## Goblin

**Tier 1**
Pest

| Threat | Damage | Health | Armor |
|---|---|---|---|
| –1 | 1 | 3 | 0 |

**Attacks:** Rusty knife, rocks, biting.
**Weakness:** Bright light drives them back.
**Desire:** Something shiny, and to see tomorrow.

## Bear

**Tier 2**
Minion

| Threat | Damage | Health | Armor |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0 | 2 | 5 | 1 |

**Attacks:** Bite, swipe, bull rush.
**Weakness:** Fire, which no animal will face.
**Desire:** To be left alone.

## Mummy

**Tier 3**
Glass Cannon

| Threat | Damage | Health | Armor |
|---|---|---|---|
| +1 | 3 | 10 | 0 |

**Attacks:** Grasping hands, choking wrappings.
**Weakness:** Fire.
**Desire:** To punish whoever opened the door.

## Ooze

**Tier 4**
Horror

| Threat | Damage | Health | Armor |
|---|---|---|---|
| +2 | 3 | 15 | 2 |

**Attacks:** Engulf, acid touch, drops from above.
**Weakness:** Salt, or high ground.
**Desire:** To dissolve and absorb metals.

## The Frayed Man

**Tier 5**
Boss

Too many joints, a second mouth, something moving under the coat.

| Threat | Damage | Health | Armor |
|---|---|---|---|
| +2 | 4 | 20 | 3 |

**Attacks:** Grasping limbs, a crushing grip.
**Casts:** Up to 8 Exposure. Bind, Drain, Mutate.
**Weakness:** Hot gossip. He just cannot get enough.
**Desire:** To kill Steve.

## The Last Dragon

**Tier 6**
Mythic

Ancient, scarred, too large for the ruins it calls home, and remembers every wound.

| Threat | Damage | Health | Armor |
|---|---|---|---|
| +3 | 5 | 30 | 5 |

**Attacks:** Crushing jaws, sweeping tail, furnace breath.
**Weakness:** It must be killed with something that has never been used as a weapon.
**Desire:** To destroy every surviving account of dragons so no one remembers how to kill one.

# Reference Tables

## Mutation Table

| d66 | Mutation |
|---|---|
| 11 | Eyes: Roll 1d6: (1) glow, (2) reflective black, (3) faded gray, (4) blood red, (5) wood, (6) purple |
| 12 | Sharp teeth |
| 13 | Long pointed elf ears |
| 14 | One body part doubles in size. Roll 1d6: (1) fingers, (2) forearms, (3) neck, (4) calves, (5) hands, (6) hips |
| 15 | Claws |
| 16 | Forked tongue |
| 21 | Your limbs become removable and reattachable. |
| 22 | Covered in: Roll 1d6: (1) fur, (2) feathers, (3) warts, (4) tiny blinking eyes, (5) moving symbols, (6) grass |
| 23 | A large shell grows on your back |
| 24 | Skin changes: Roll 1d6: (1) bark, (2) metal, (3) scales, (4) rock, (5) barnacles, (6) see-through skin |
| 25 | Grow a large tail |
| 26 | Turn into a talking version of your childhood pet |
| 31 | 1d6 more eyes |
| 32 | Covered in moss, and vining plants |
| 33 | Antlers |
| 34 | Grow long, pointed horns from your head |
| 35 | Your skull becomes soft and your brain doubles in size, pulsing with light. You can read people's emotions. |
| 36 | Grow wings |
| 41 | Your flesh becomes soft wax that can be reshaped. |
| 42 | Hear and smell 10x better. Loud sounds or strong smells bother you. |
| 43 | Become a talking house cat |
| 44 | Burning touch |
| 45 | Grow 1d6 long tentacles from your back |
| 46 | Bird legs |
| 51 | A second mouth |
| 52 | A second face, on the back of your head |
| 53 | Reptilian, cold and slit-eyed |
| 54 | Limbs become moving roots |
| 55 | Your size changes. Roll 1d6: (1) mouse, (2) cat, (3) young child, (4) horse, (5) one-story house, (6) four-story building |
| 56 | A single red eye grows from your forehead while your other eyes shrink to nothing |
| 61 | Float 4 feet above the ground |
| 62 | Become a moving piece of ice and freeze everything you touch |
| 63 | Become faceless |
| 64 | Your form changes. Roll 1d6: (1) gas, (2) ooze, (3) water, (4) rock, (5) fire, (6) energy |
| 65 | Your hands become giant crab claws |
| 66 | Come apart into a swarm of bugs with a hive mind. |

## Wild Magic

| d66 | Wild Magic |
|---|---|
| 11 | Wild lights fill the sky. |
| 12 | Every is covered in sticky green slime. |
| 13 | Total darkness covered the play area for 1d6 days. |
| 14 | Inanimate objects come to life. Roll d6: 1. They are all singing a childish song, 2. Screaming because nothing makes sense, 3. Thinks the first largish creature they see is their mommy, 4. All singing different songs... badly, 5. Scary laughing, 6. Projectile committing... everywhere |
| 15 | Everyone is teleported to a small bathroom of, Roll d6: 1. a castle during a wedding, 2. a clown performance at a low rent circus, 3. a den of crime during a raid, 4. a kids birthday party where no one showed up, 5. a keep on a mountain peak deep in the north, 6. a closed art museum |
| 16 | Tiny flying fairies emerge and shoot stinging blasts of energy at everyone. |
| 21 | The whole region is cast into a permanent Snowy winter. |
| 22 | Flash flood rolls through the area. Wiping out buildings and changing the landscape. |
| 23 | Gravity loses its grip, it's like walking on the moon. |
| 24 | The wondering magical merchant appears with strange things to sell. Will take your soul as payment. Harming him is a bad idea. |
| 25 | Everyone you can see grows a tail |
| 26 | Everyone you can see forgets who they are and why they are there. |
| 31 | The air becomes so think you can swim through it for 1d6 days. |
| 32 | For 1 hour gravity shifts to the walls or the ceiling. |
| 33 | The caster is infused with intense electricity. They can shoot lightning from their hands for 1d6 days. |
| 34 | Everyone nearby shrinks to mouse size for 1d6 hours. |
| 35 | A dense forest and mature forest instantly grow around you in every direction for miles. |
| 36 | For 1d6 days every door within a mile of you opens to the spirit realm. |
| 41 | Fog so dense you can't see your hand in front of your face. Lasts 1d6 hours. |
| 42 | Everyone nearby becomes transparent except for their bones for the 1d6 days. |
| 43 | Nearby metal softens like clay for 1d6 hours. |
| 44 | 1d6 individual in the room are turned into vampires. |
| 45 | Dead creature claw their way through the floor. 1d6 of them every hour for 1d6 months. |
| 46 | A huge creature falls from the sky: Roll 1d6, 1. A whale, 2. A dragon, 3. Gelatinous cube, 4. Spooky ghost, 5. Huge red dog, 6. A giant looking for his goose that lays golden eggs. |
| 51 | Every nonliving thing nearby turns to sand. |
| 52 | You switch bodies with the person or creature you are looking at. |
| 53 | Everyone you can see is turned into: 1. Children, 2. Very old women, 3. Talking dogs, 4. Talking cats, 5. Talking raccoons, 6. Cookie people |
| 54 | A giant pyramid emerges from the ground under you. Its contents likely treasures of a demon who was trying to hide from prying eyes. |
| 55 | Plants erupt from every crack, splitting roads, walls, and foundations as they consume the area. |
| 56 | A pillar of glowing energy erupts from the ground 20 feet tall, 3 feet wide. It emits a lot of heat. |
| 61 | The surrounding area becomes dead land. Plants die, water spoils, and nothing grows here anymore. |
| 62 | A portal to a void dimension tears open and stays open, pulling things into it like a vacuum. |
| 63 | Gravity reverses across the area permanently. Anything unanchored falls into the sky. |
| 64 | Every one near by rolls on the mutation table. |
| 65 | You become invisible for 1d6 days. |
| 66 | The area around you is torn from its spot and floats into the clouds. Where it is now stuck. Slowly drifting through the sky. |

## Spell Tag Sparks

When a player needs a Spell Tag idea, roll once or choose one. To create a monster caster, roll twice and combine the results into a casting theme. **Fire + Memory** might burn away memories. **Bone + Space** might call distant skeletons.

| d66 | Spark |
|---|---|
| 11 | Fire |
| 12 | Ice |
| 13 | Lightning |
| 14 | Wind |
| 15 | Water |
| 16 | Stone |
| 21 | Light |
| 22 | Darkness |
| 23 | Sound |
| 24 | Gravity |
| 25 | Time |
| 26 | Magnetism |
| 31 | Speed |
| 32 | Slime |
| 33 | Scale |
| 34 | Plants |
| 35 | Animals |
| 36 | Swarms |
| 41 | Explosion |
| 42 | locating |
| 43 | Undead |
| 44 | Illusion |
| 45 | Acid |
| 46 | Speed |
| 51 | Flying |
| 52 | Binding |
| 53 | Transformation |
| 54 | Invisibility |
| 55 | Sleep |
| 56 | Healing |
| 61 | Portal |
| 62 | Mind reading |
| 63 | Duplication |
| 64 | Disease |
| 65 | Decay |
| 66 | Weather |

## Key Ideas

### Making money

Arcanists can make and sell relics. For some, it is a living. Wizarding schools may keep their Arcanist suppliers on the down-low. Common folk do not need to know that their magic items come from people slowly turning into monsters.

### Magic is a team sport

Magic can be a team effort. Separate casts can build on each other.

One character creates fire, another opens a portal, and a third blows the fire through it. Price and roll each cast separately. Each character gains Exposure for their own cast.

### Arcanists might be scary

Anyone who can rewrite reality is dangerous. Common folk may fear Arcanists. Powerful people may hunt, recruit, hide, or control them before they grow into demigods.

## Key Terms

- **Aether:** The particles and patterns that make up reality.
- **Arcanist:** A person who can perceive and command those patterns.
- **Exposure:** Raw Aether accumulated through casting.
- **Magic Magnitude:** The overall scale of a spell, setting its Exposure cost. See Core Rules.
- **Exposure Tolerance:** Exposure a character can handle in one successful cast without Fatigue, equal to 3 plus their number of Mutations. See Core Rules.
- **Mutation:** A permanent change caused by Exposure.
- **Spell Tag:** Something the character's magic has learned to do reliably.
- **Health:** How much damage a character or monster can take before suffering worse consequences.
- **Relic:** An object that stores Exposure and performs one kind of magic.
- **Frayed:** A common term for an Arcanist visibly changed by Exposure.
- **Demon:** An Arcanist whose final inventory slot was claimed by a Mutation.

# The Arcane Aether

**Armor**

Broken

**Health**

Max | Current

**Character Details**

**Name** **Age**

**Life Type** **Archetype**

**Description**

| STR | DEX | WILL | CHARM | COIN |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | |

**Luck**

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

**Inventory**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | | |
| 2 | | |
| 3 | | |
| 4 | | |
| 5 | | |
| 6 | | |
| 7 | | |
| 8 | | |
| 9 | | |
| 10 | | |
| 11 | | |
| 12 | | |

**Mutations, Scars, and Fatigue**

**Spell Tags**

**Aether Exposure** 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

**Other Details / Notes**

**Key Goals**

**Traits & Perks**